Incident Report INC-2026-0324: Delayed payment notifications

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Status: Final

Summary

From 22:10 UTC on 2026-03-23 to 01:15 UTC on 2026-03-24, payment receipt emails and merchant webhooks were delayed by up to 3 hours. The cause was a consumer group rebalancing loop in notification-service after the Kafka broker upgrade CHG-2051.

Impact

- Severity: SEV-3
- About 41,000 notifications were delayed. None were lost.
- Card payments were processed normally. payment-gateway and merchant-api were not affected.

Affected services

- notification-service

Root cause

CHG-2051 upgraded the Kafka brokers from version 3.6 to 3.7. The notification-service consumers used a session timeout shorter than the new broker's rebalance delay, so they were repeatedly removed from the consumer group and processing stalled.

Resolution

The consumer session timeout was raised from 10 to 45 seconds at 00:40 UTC. The backlog had drained by 01:15 UTC.